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How to design infographics

How we design infographics for BBC editorial content and how you can make your own.

Contributors



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What is an infographic?

The term 'infographic' comes from 'information graphic' - a visual representation of information or data. They should educate and inform people in a quick, clear and engaging way.

At the BBC, our infographics usually fall under one of four categories:

Diagrams/technical illustrations

These are usually an illustration of a physical object or some kind of process.

The most important elements will be labelled to show people where the key information is.

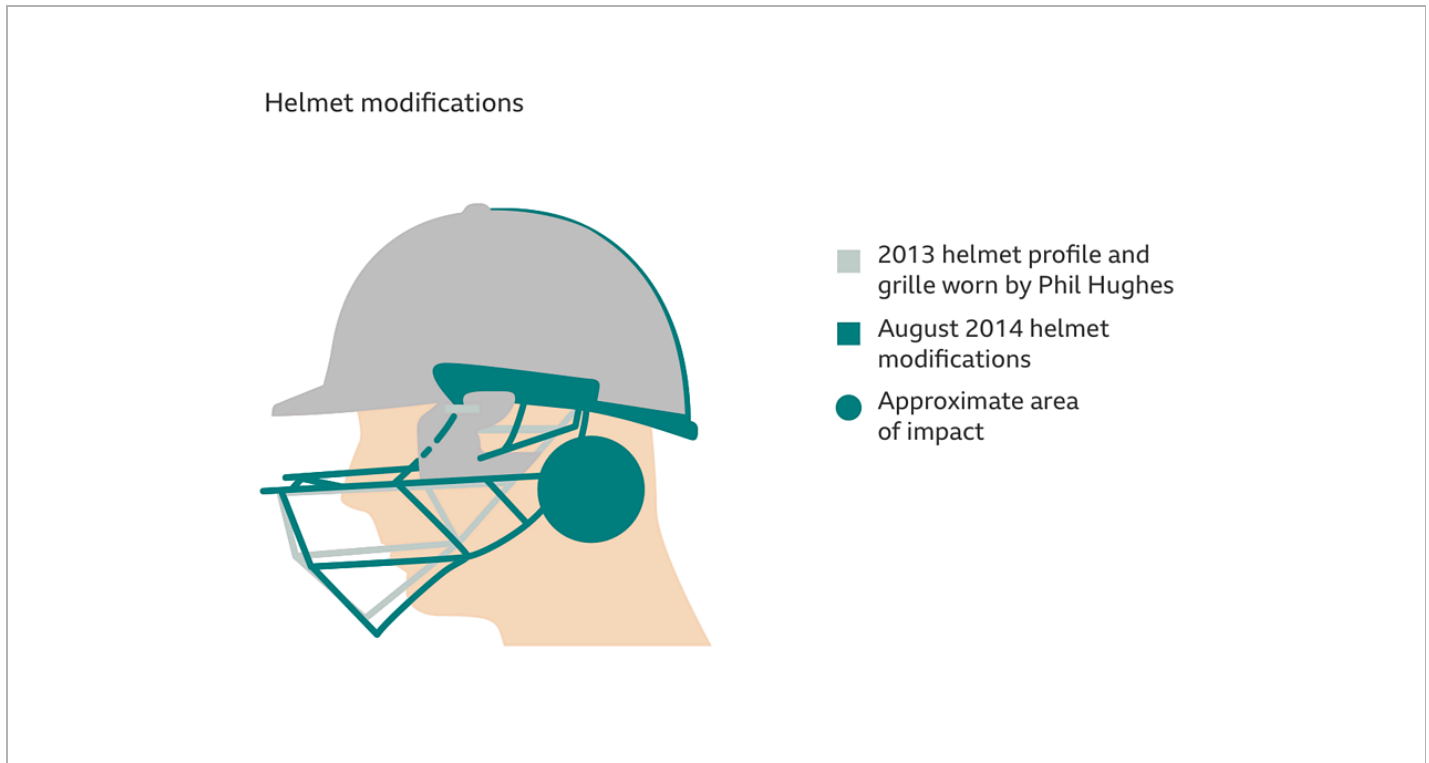


Fig 1 An example of a diagram from a BBC News story

Data visualisation

This type of infographic helps people find meaning in data. The simplest ones highlight a single value, compare one value against another or compare values over time. The most common forms are column, bar, line and pie charts.

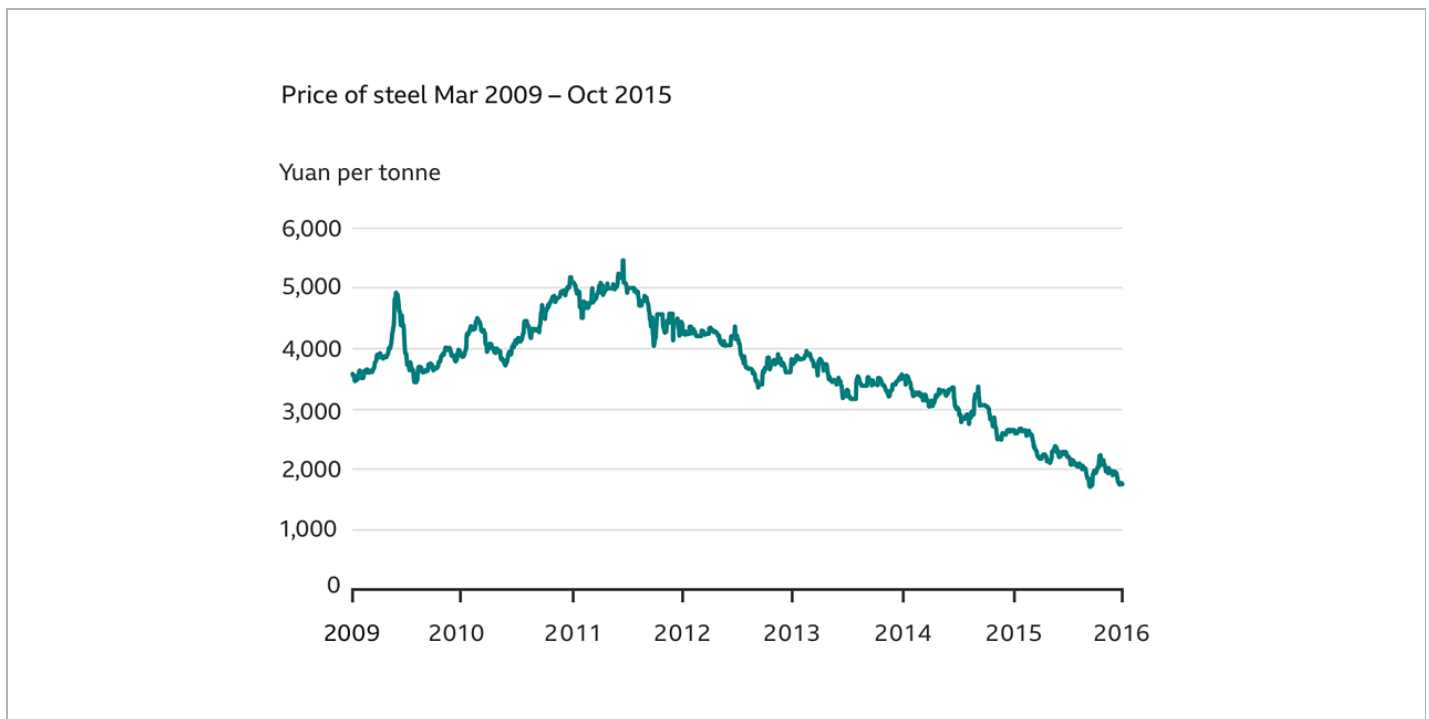


Fig 2 An example of a line graph from a BBC News story

Annotations

As soon as you add a label to an image, it arguably becomes an infographic. Labels can be used to highlight key information within the image.



Fig 3 An example of an annotated image from BBC News

Maps

We use maps to show where things have happened and the relationship between events in an area. These are usually two-dimensional plan views of three-dimensional space with labels, keys and scales to help people understand a story.



Fig 4 An example of a BBC News map

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What makes a good infographic

Good infographics should aim to follow some of these principles, a great infographic will follow all three...

Informative

Be informative, accurate and reveal the story in the information. We must add value to our infographics, presenting what text alone can't communicate. Generally we aim to bring clarity and understanding where there is complexity and confusion.

Engaging

Create a visually stimulating and engaging experience that will capture the viewers attention and be something they'll want to spend time reading. You should invite people to explore and contemplate and help them find personal relevance and context.

Accessible

Aim to reach all audiences by communicating with the clearest language and the simplest techniques. Remove the unnecessary visual clutter to create a clear and simple experience. And remember, some people physically see things differently or not at all.



Fig 5 A Venn diagram showing the principles for a great infographic

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Infographic visual style overview

Illustration

Our overall visual style is minimal and visually engaging but with a neutral tone. News, Sport and GEL have their own distinctive style that compliments their brand and editorial values.

Simplify the complex

Reduce the amount of unnecessary information, so the important things are clear.

Use colour with care

Use a neutral colour palette so important information stands out more in comparison.

Don't convey meaning with colour alone. Not everyone sees colours the same. Combine colour differences with shape variety, patterns or icons. For example, the GEL infographics use green and red circles combined with tick and cross icons to show correct and incorrect designs. The **colour and meaning guideline** gives more information.

Consider tone

Consider the tone of the story and people's expectations. Too simple and the illustrations may look playful, too detailed and they might become too real or serious.

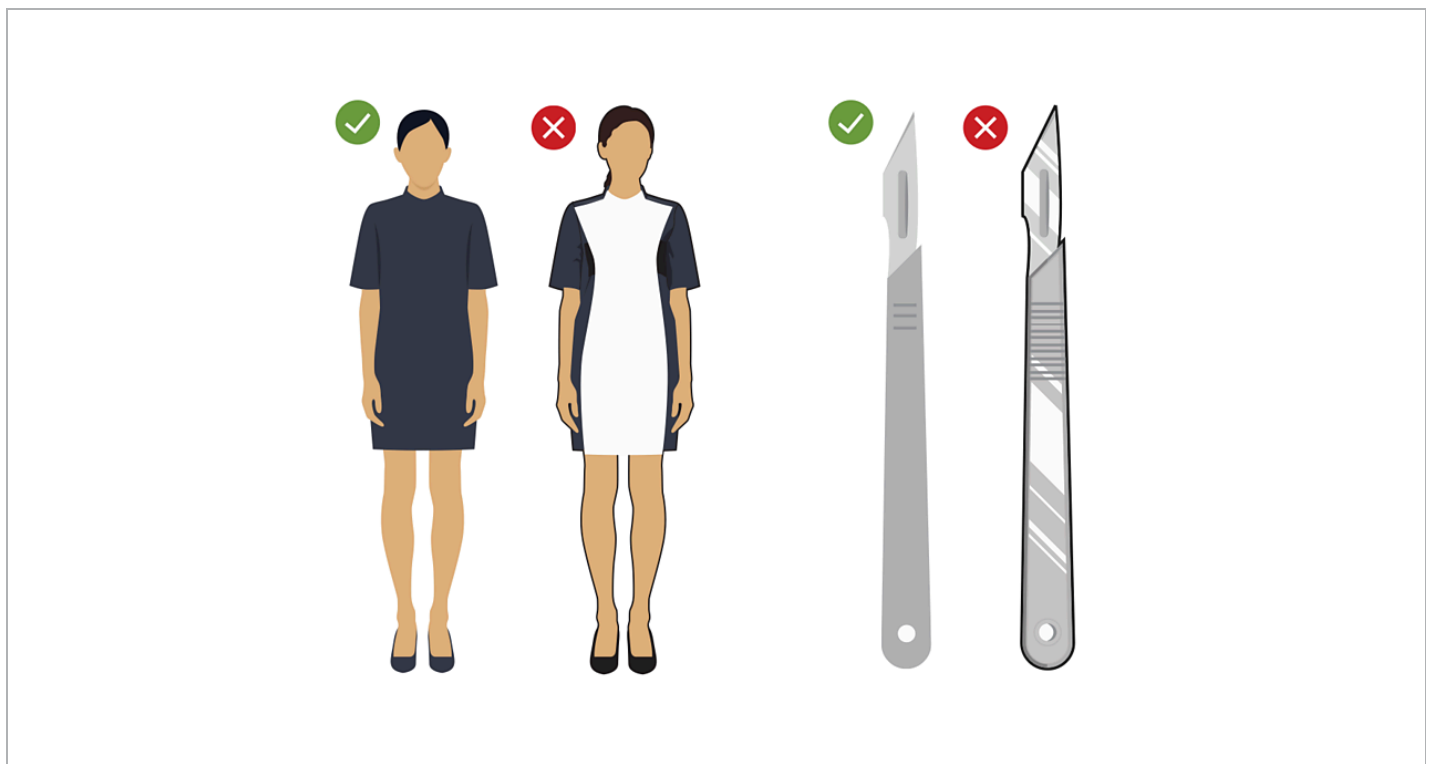


Fig 6 A diagram demonstrating the right level of detail for a BBC infographic

Remove unnecessary details to make a graphic easier to read. Avoid decoration and make things simple. But also don't overdo it and give things a cartoonish tone. If you're using digital illustration software, use minimal points on Bézier curves.

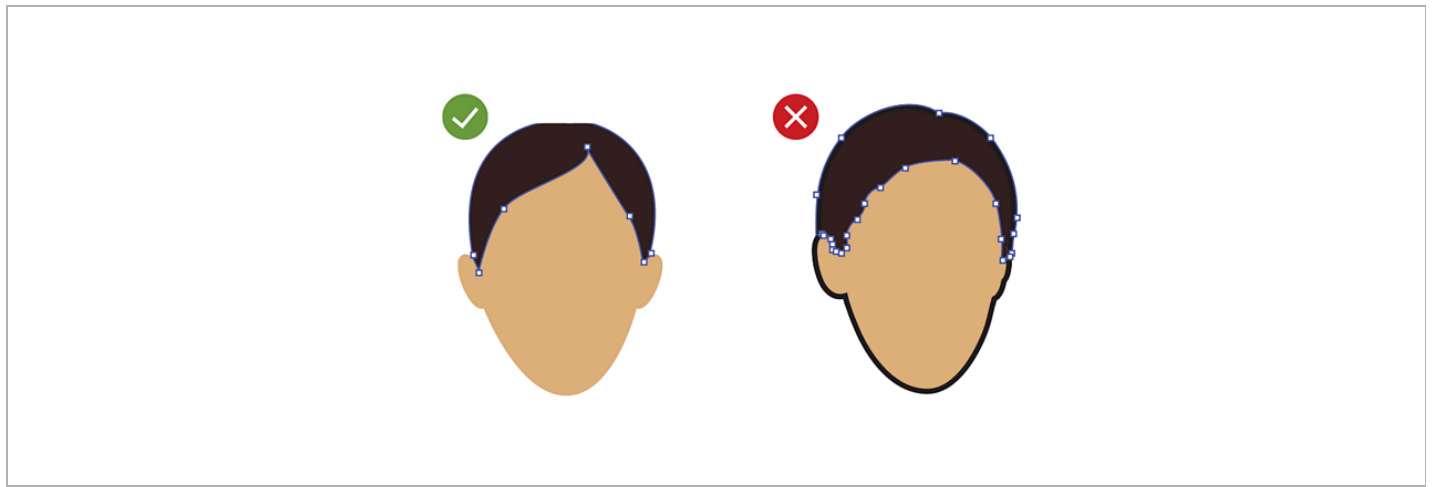


Fig 7 A diagram demonstrating the use of bezier curves for simple shapes

Scale

The smaller the image is, the less detail you need.

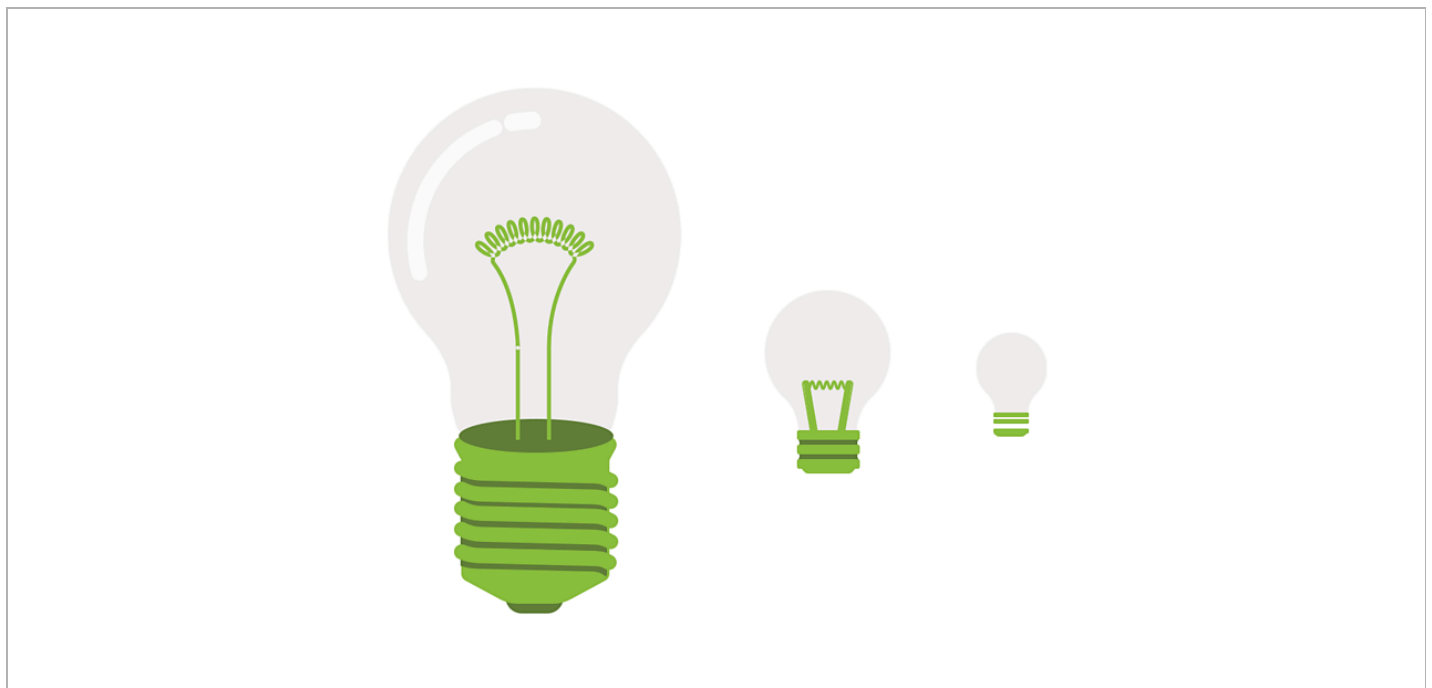


Fig 8 An example of how illustration detail can reduce as an image element scales down

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Visual style variety

Here's an overview of the elements across BBC News, Sport and GEL.

BBC News examples

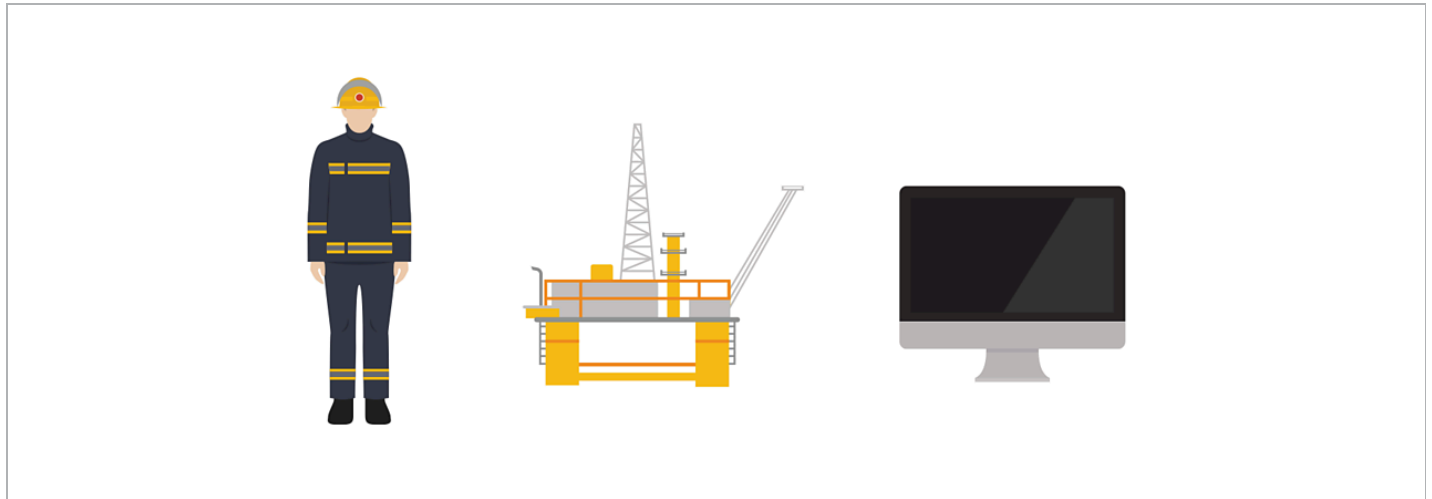


Fig 9 Examples of the BBC News illustration style

BBC Sport examples



Fig 10 Examples of the BBC Sport illustration style

BBC GEL examples



Fig 11 Examples of the BBC GEL illustration style

Colour palette

Each BBC product has its own specific colour palette for infographics. These colours are carefully chosen to compliment the brand colours of that product.

Within each product we use a set range of colours when illustrating certain things such as buildings or nature. We also use set colours to highlight key information to make an infographic easier to understand.

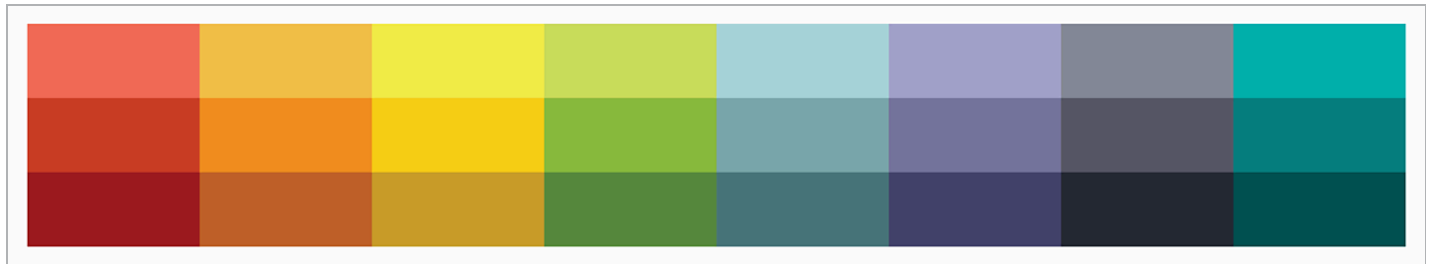


Fig 12 A selection of the colours used in BBC infographics

The full range of palettes can be found in the downloadable infographics asset file. This can be found via the link at the top of this page.

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Visual style consistency

Here's an overview of the elements of visual style which are consistent across all BBC products.

Typography

BBC Reith is used as our main typeface for all infographics. For type sizing the **GEL typography guideline** should be followed where possible.

To optimise infographics across all devices, they are generally created in three different sizes: small, medium and large. The table below shows how the infographic text attributes can be applied using the GEL typography sizes.

Text colour should contrast well with the colour or colours behind it. The **colour contrast guideline** gives more information.

Example usage	Type sizes
Title	Great primer
Subheader	Great primer
Label	Pica
Source	Brevier

Labels

We design labels to be as consistent as possible across the BBC, though we can change the colour and style of label where appropriate.

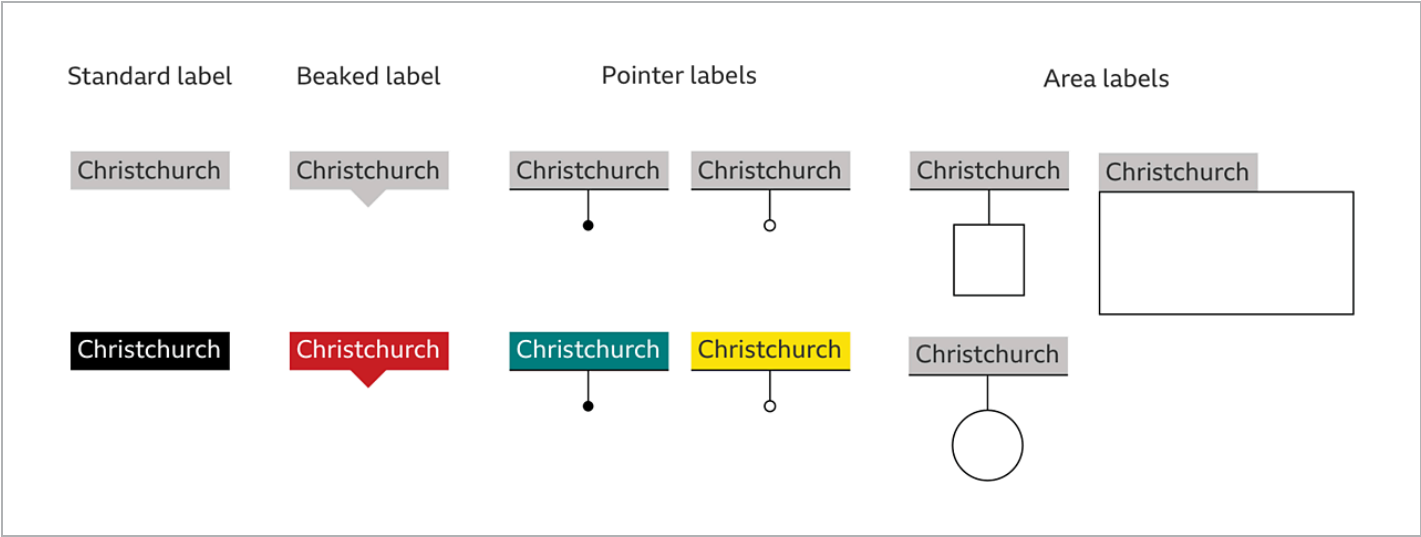


Fig 13 The label styles used in BBC infographics

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Responsive infographics

We design infographics to give a good experience across a range of devices and browsers.

Infographics are created at up to three different sizes: small, medium and large. Depending on the size of someone's display, a different graphic will be shown. For example, if you're on a small screen, like a phone, you'll see the small graphic.

To give the best reading experience, infographics have a different layout depending on what size they are. Small (mobile) is presented as a vertical stack while medium (tablet) and large (desktop) have a more horizontal layout.

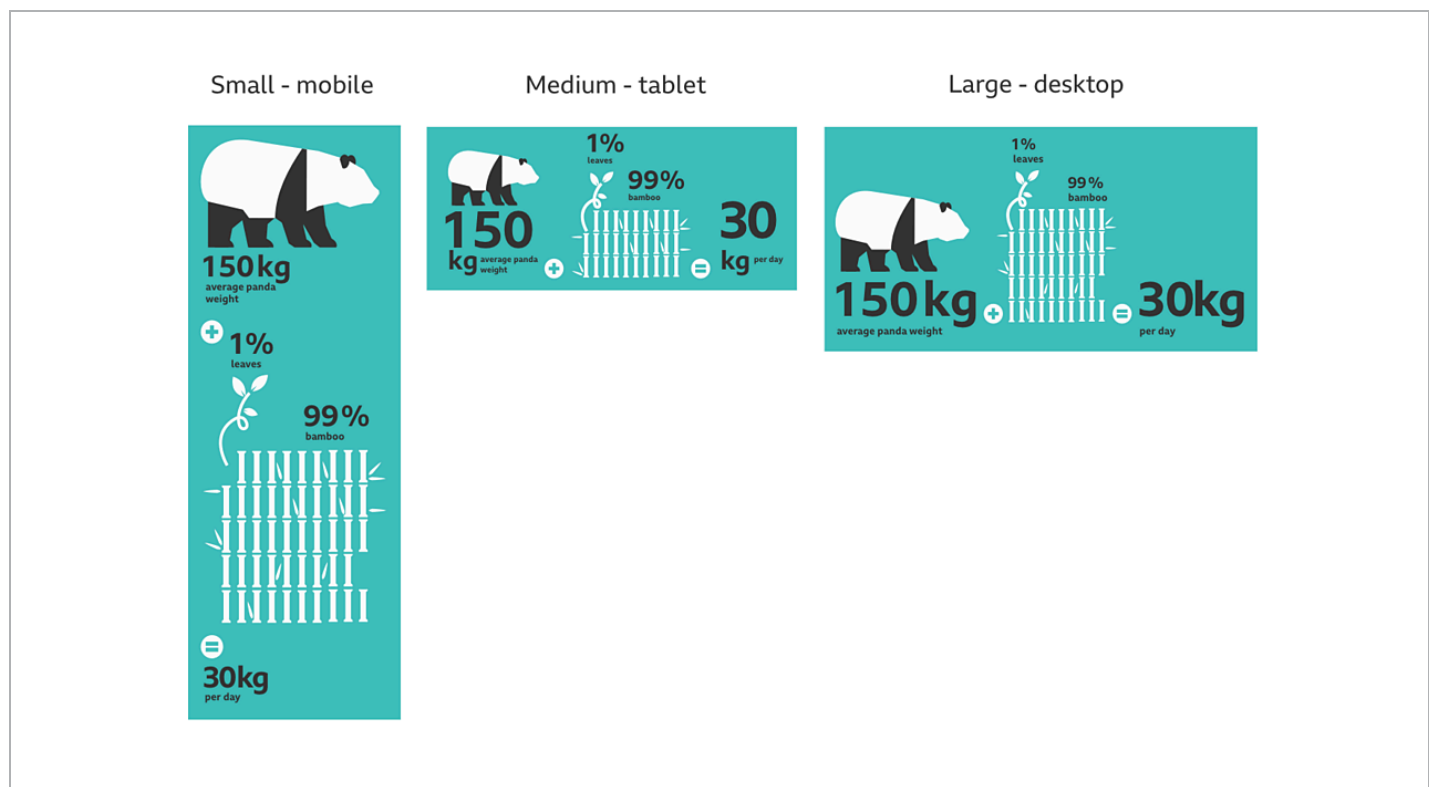


Fig 14 An example of how layout changes on mobile, tablet and desktop (example from BBC iWonder)

Infographics adapt in size to best fit the device/browser, but we have fixed widths at which we create them (we do not have fixed depths).

The widths below show the best averages that we use to scale our adaptive infographics across devices.

	Small	Medium	Large
Graphic width (px)	400	750	976
Device ranges (px)	0 - 400	401 - 750	751 - 976+

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Accessibility

Some key considerations when creating infographics are:

- **Colour contrast** - Text colour should contrast well with the colour or colours behind it.
- **Colour and meaning** - Meaning should not be implied by colour alone.
- **Text alternatives** - Text that is only part of an infographic (jpg, gif or png) is not accessible. Neither is an image without a text alternative.

You can find out more in our [how to design for accessibility guideline](#) or visit the [BBC mobile accessibility guidelines](#).

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